



Synthesis and Sustainability: The Evolution of Markup and Toolsets in the Women Writers Project

Ash Clark and Julia Flanders
Women Writers Project
Northeastern University
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About the Women Writers Project

A project organized around two research programs: early women's writing and markup...

...embedded in large, eclectic academic digital research and development groups...

...with a strong pedagogical dimension

What this topic means to us: Tools??

Allen Renear, 1994: “There will be tools...!!!”

John Bosak, 1999, TEI conference keynote: “There will be tools...!!!”

Us WWP folk, encoding without a parser: “Who needs tools???”

What this topic means to us: Tools 😡

Tools:

- limiting interactions with your data
- tempting data designers into intellectual concessions
- creating a bad set of incentives

🤯🤢😞😓😡 Coding to the tool! 🤯🤢😞😓😡

What this topic means to us: The schema as a tool?

“In brief, the TEI Guidelines define a general-purpose encoding scheme which makes it possible to encode different views of text, possibly intended for different applications, serving the majority of scholarly purposes of text studies in the humanities. Because no predefined encoding scheme can possibly serve all research purposes, the TEI scheme is designed to facilitate both selection from a wide range of predefined markup choices, and the addition of new (non-TEI) markup options. By providing a formally verifiable means of extending the TEI recommendations, the TEI makes it simple for such user-identified modifications to be incorporated into future releases of these Guidelines as they evolve.”

—TEI P5, “About These Guidelines”

What this topic means to us: Tool research!

Renear, Lawton, Philippe, Dubin: “An XML document corresponds to which FRBR Group 1 entity?” ([Extreme Markup Languages, 2003](#))

Elena Pierazzo, “Just Different Layers? Stylesheets and Digital Edition Methodology” (Digital Humanities 2006)

Julia Flanders, “The Rhetoric of Performative Markup” (Digital Humanities 2006)

The evolution of a tool philosophy: early industrial borrowing

For the WWP in the early days of the Web:

- tools as a representation of capital
- they are large; we are tiny!
- they are standard; we are exceptional!

The evolution of a tool philosophy: community development

With the rise of “Digital Humanities” in early 2000s:

- Greater naturalization of tools and skill sets within the DH community
- Greater interest in “our” data and its distinctive use cases and challenges
- Greater emphasis on adaptability and modularity, anticipating usage by small, idiosyncratic, low-cost projects

The evolution of a tool philosophy: sustainable life cycles

The moment in which we now find ourselves:

- a long history behind us that speaks to the fragility of big systems
- a strong focus on sustainability and environmental impact
- data is a principle of longevity, but this may require adapting our tool philosophy

The Endings Principles

“Principles for Digital Longevity”

- endings.uvic.ca/principles.html
- Came out of the Endings Project, convened by University of Victoria's Humanities Computing and Media Centre (HCMC)
- A site is “arguably the most recognizable and least preservable part of a digital project”
- Recommendations for data, documentation, code, site
 - Easy to hand over
 - Easy to archive

The Endings Principles: assumptions

The Endings Principles assume

- the tools, data, and digital products are part of the same ecology
- tools are impermanent
- supporting transparency and openness aids reuptake, reuse
 - ...and survival

Synthesis

- Tools and data share an ecology
 - ...and have meaningful things to say to each other
- The manifestation of data in the world comes about through tools

Where this might lead: research questions?

1. How can we make tools a benign and cheap aspect of digital humanities project development and support?
2. How can we make tools that engage users more directly with the data, not less?

Thank you!!!! Questions? Thoughts?

Link to the slides: <https://bit.ly/3S6twrV>

